



WASTED

ON

THE

YOUNG

RESEARCH PROJECT STAGE 2
JAMES KENDALL

CONTENTS

- 1. ARTIST STATEMENT
- 2. PRESENTATION AND ANALYSIS OF PROJECT
- 3. STAGES OF RESEARCH PROCESS
- 4. EXHIBITION VIEW
- 5. FINAL WORK
- 6. AMMENDED ANNOTATED PORTFOLIO OF VISUAL RESOURCES AND ADDITIONAL RESEARCH
- 7. BIBLIOGRAPHY
- 8. APPENDICES
 - A. EVIDENCE OF ARTIST TALK
 - B. STAGE 2 PROPOSAL
 - C. STAGE 1 PROCESS

ARTIST STATEMENT

Wasted On The Young is in service to the understanding of the intersection of ageing, youth culture and identity. As we slip quietly into middle age, many of us find ourselves adrift, life in the home taking over from communal obsessions that drove us as adolescents. The subjects of these photographs have found a space in their lives to stay connected to the parts of themselves that felt meaningful as young adults.

The project does not advocate for a singular path in embracing middle age but instead reflects upon the diversity of experiences. It portrays a life where the middle-aged can find joy in the activities that once defined their younger selves while simultaneously embracing the serene moments that come with maturity. Wasted On The Young makes no judgement on whether everyone should hold on to a part of their youth so directly, but offers it as a potential path for reconnection with either the world or a sense of self.

By capturing these contrasting worlds, Wasted On The Young endeavours to alter preconceived notions of ageing, suggesting that there’s a world where the ecstasy of youth can coexist with the wisdom and tranquility of middle age.

“Happy Meldrew Point Day, Matthew Perry! Today you are 19,537 days old and have reached your Meldrew Point - the age of Richard Wilson on the day One Foot In The Grave was first aired on Jan 4, 1990. I don't believe it!”

Meldrew Point Twitter Account (2023)

“I was at a house party recently and my friend was up dancing. She said, “If I don't do this now, I'll be dancing in the aisles of Tesco.” It's rare to find those moments as you get older, but 30 years of clubbing means it's something that's deep in you. You hear good music and you just want to dance.”

Victoria Saunders, 50, hairdresser (Guardian, 2023)

“There's a lot of people here that look like they enjoy 6 Music! Steve Lamacz has played us if that helps.”

Welly a band in their early 20s looking out over an older crowd, in support of Heartworms at Green Door Store, Brighton (2023)

PRESENTATION AND ANALYSIS OF PROJECT

When Victor Meldrew was described as having One Foot In The Grave in the 1990 sitcom, he was 53 years old. The idea of him being on the dancefloor at 2am, arms raised in collective euphoria to the latest techno track is near unimaginable. And yet in 2023 some middle-aged people are doing just that. Wasted On The Young explores the changing nature of middle age, and investigates further themes of collective joy, connection and the intersection of youth culture and ageing. For this dossier I will focus on the change in middle age.

A recent survey from the ticketing platform Eventbrite revealed that over 3.7 million Britons over the age of 45 attend clubs weekly. “What starts as an act of teenage transgression becomes radical in middle age,” says Crummy (2019). Lisa Edgar, Chief Customer Officer at Saga, notes a transformative shift in societal perspectives on ageing. She argues that the over-50s are actively redefining age-related expectations, viewing their later years as “freedom years” to explore new opportunities, such as attending festivals. This is replicated in the average age of festival headliners: in 1997, it was 26 years of age, but by 2019, it had risen to 49.

These photos invite viewers to rethink how they see middle age. Some younger viewers of the work have suggested that the subjects don't look “old”, but that is somewhat the point – the goal isn't to highlight older subjects to provide a spectacle, but to make visible to the middle-aged a representation of themselves. The work can also help younger viewers question their assumptions about their own middle age, drawing a difference from what they observed in their parents at that age. These images emphasise the idea that age doesn't define how engaged or passionate you are about life, that perhaps we all feel as alive and curious as we did in our twenties.

“There’s a general sense that mothers are expected to give up certain things, like raving for instance. Women are expected to lead a completely different life once they have children. I believe in balance and not adhering to boxes or stereotypes and I didn’t see enough representation of women like us.”

Mums That Rave, Interview With Cinemamas (2020)



The Golden Girls, aged between 51 and 63; right, the cast of And Just Like That, in their mid-50s (1985/2023)

The representation of women in the project is critical. Older women have been particularly invisible, and even unwelcomed in nightclubs. In her study of the VIP clubbing scene, various promoters told Mears (2021) that women in their thirties who frequent nightclubs have a lack of direction in life or present “desperation.” “Gross! Those forty-year-olds are wearing totally age-inappropriate clothing,” 30-year-old Anna told Mears. “When I’m forty, I hope I’m not in a fucking club.” Gullette (1999, quoted in Mackinney-Valentin, 2017) contends that midlife is nearly equated with being out of fashion. She links the end of a product’s fashion cycle with “age identity”, implying that as fashion celebrates youth, ageing becomes associated with the waning desirability of a product. Hence, older women are perceived analogously to outdated clothing items.

Coplans, in his 1994 interview with Berlind, lamented society’s stance that “old is ugly” (1994, reprinted in Art And Photography, 2007). Shape, colour, form, light and tonality can all work towards providing a “beautiful image” with Bate (2000) pointing out, that beauty is achieved by things (from compositional elements to poor peasants found working in the fields) being in their “right place”. While considering the representation of the subjects in this project, beauty becomes a useful tool. Harbison (2016) sees beauty as a trojan horse to enable us to see things afresh. Beauty is a double-edged sword, as Brand (2000) recognises, and can be a tool for destabilising rigid conventions and well as reinforcing them, especially in photographing women.

The contemporary perception of the midlife crisis, often depicted as a male-centric phase marked by indulgence and recklessness, was originally presented as a feminist concept addressing both genders. As Schmidt (2017) points out, Gail Sheehy’s influential ‘Passages’ (1976) portrayed middle-age as a liberating period from domestic roles, particularly for women. Despite the later age women are having children, this would point to their visibility both on the dancefloor and in the project itself. This perspective illuminates Susan Sontag’s 1972 analysis of the

“But I’m losing my edge,
To better-looking people with better
ideas and more talent,
And they’re actually really, really nice.”
**LCD Soundsystem, ‘Losing My Edge’
(2002)**

“These were people who, like me, used
to love to dance when younger but
unlike me they refused to believe they
needed to stop. When Bridget asked me
to come I agreed — but only because
I assumed it would be so awful that it
might provide material for this column. I
could not have been more wrong.”
**Sarfraz Manzoor, Evening Standard
(2023)**

“When we go to Ibiza now, we do it
differently. We have dinner, then we
have a nap, then we go out, whereas
before we’d keep going all day. You just
have to adjust when you get older.”
Sarah, Vice (2020)

ageing double standard, emphasising how women employed the concept of midlife transformation to challenge gender norms. Sontag articulated that society penalises women more harshly for ageing, in contrast to the leniency shown towards men’s ageing and infidelity. My representation of women in the project aims to be mindful of this double standard.

Jung suggested that life comprises two phases: the early years focus on external achievements, such as career and identity formation, while the latter half shifts inwards, exploring meaning and spirituality (the age of 45 stands out as the peak age for diagnosing depression). This notion aligns with psychologist Elliot Jacques’s 1965 conception of the ‘mid-life crisis,’ wherein he noticed a transition from youthful fervour to refined creativity in artists post their mid-30s (Jacques, 1965). This introspection during middle age is also echoed all the way back to William Langland’s 1400 poem, *Piers Plowman*, where the protagonist seeks life’s purpose, prompted by ‘Imagination’ to reflect and act before his vigour diminishes (Langland, 1400). The return to the dancefloor perhaps plays into this desire to use this vigour before it’s gone.

In today’s digital age, younger demographics have intertwined their self-image with social media platforms, where actions, like a night out, can quickly redefine one’s online reputation. Perhaps past generations showcased more genuine moments, pointing to broader socio-cultural shifts from private photographs to public online displays. Modern photography, rather than just a memory tool, serves societal surveillance and judgment. Even in spaces emphasising fleeting moments, like dancefloors, there’s an observed desire for being photographed, emphasising a need for visibility. It’s noteworthy that I was never tackled in the nightclubs when taking photos (though I was when I took a photo on a bus). This intricate relationship between subject, photographer, and evolving photography spaces provokes interesting questions, especially when considering privacy, self-representation, and constant digital observation.

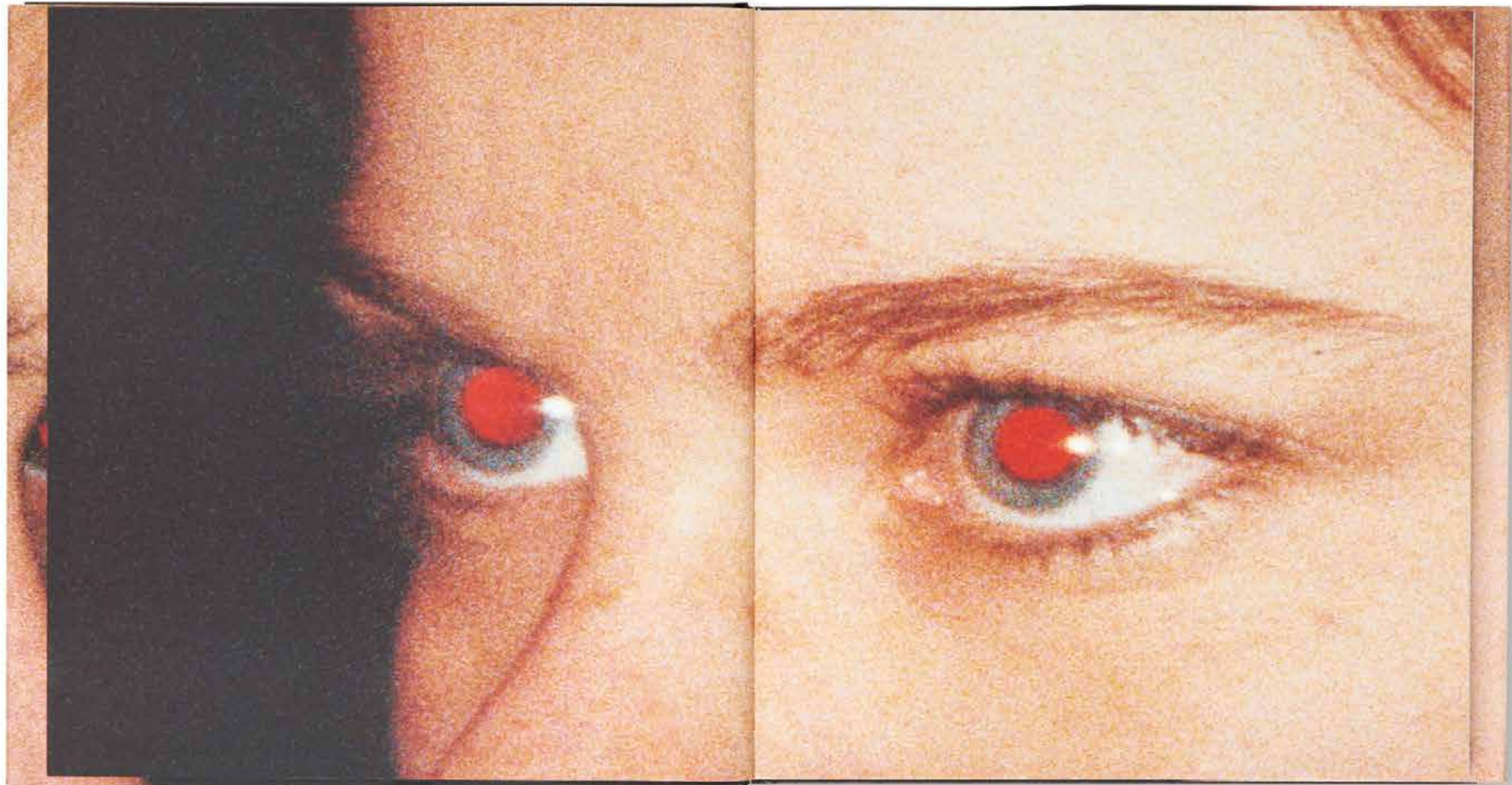
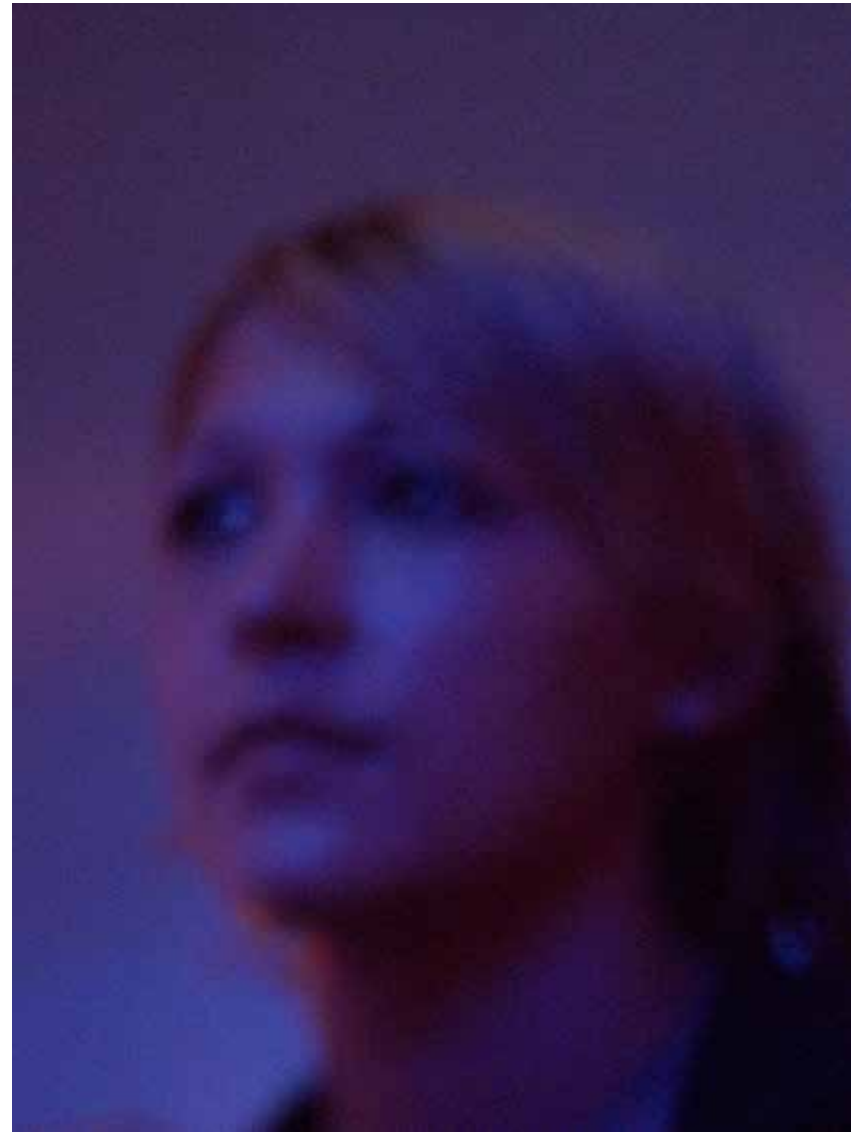
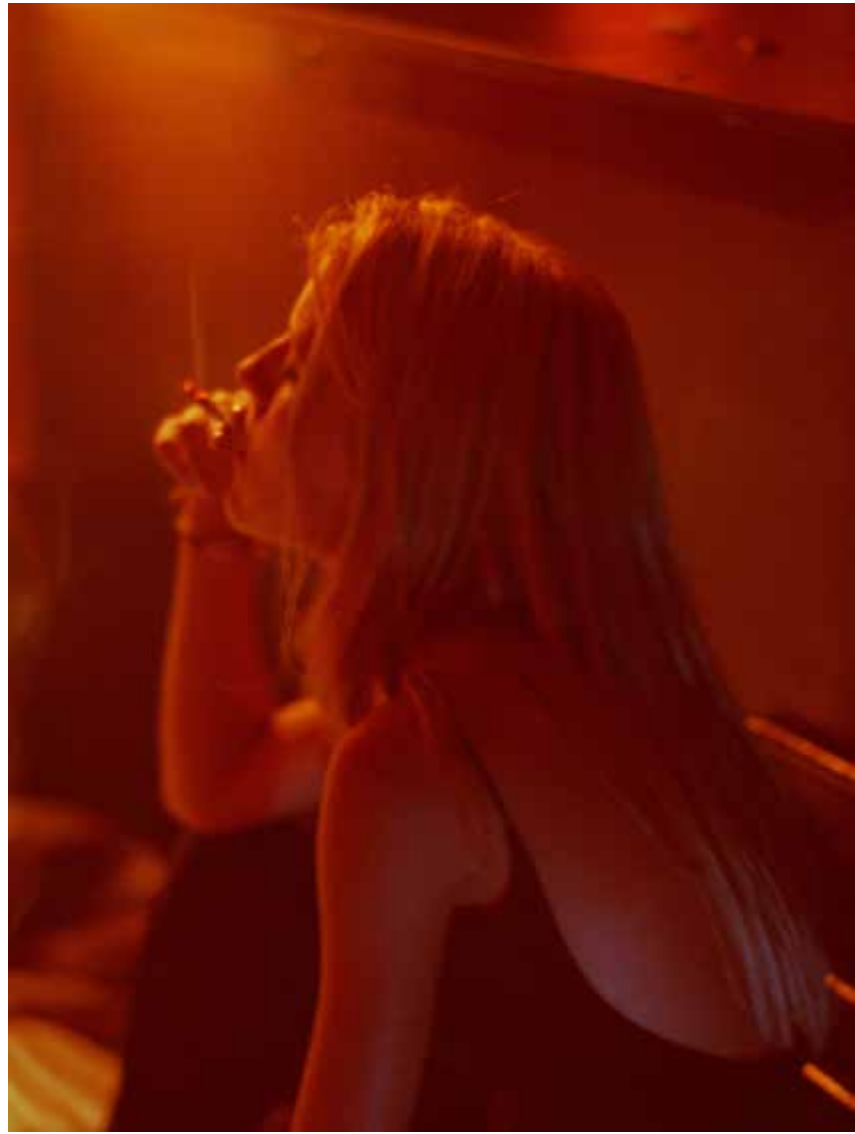


In the 1990s dance music media promoted a specific aesthetic, leading to performative behaviours for camera attention (essentially straight girls kissing for the camera). While initially hesitant, nightclub attendees became more receptive to photography, especially with clubs commissioning photographers for online sharing. This prompted subjects, particularly women, to actively engage with the photographer, consciously framing themselves for the lens. No longer passive subjects, they would meticulously arrange themselves, having ascertained their most flattering angles and postures. This reflexive awareness transformed these ephemeral moments into ritualised tableaux, resonating more with the meticulous compositions of classical portraiture than spontaneous nightclub snapshots. This evolution highlights the changing dynamics between the subject and photographer, emphasising broader discussions on self-representation and image interpretation in today's visual culture.



Drawing parallels with Martha Rosler's observations in provincial Russia during the late 1980s, where subjects exhibited uncorrupted natural behaviour "not yet corrupted by the optical unconscious" (Tupitsyn in his essay *Canny Uncanny in Stripped Bare*, 2004), individuals "lost in music" (or perhaps merely drunk) in *Wasted On The Young* also tend to disregard representation. Our self-perception is influenced by societal expectations and popular media, which offer clichéd images to emulate. Thus, representation becomes analogous to attire or cosmetics - both mass-produced and catered to appease an audience conditioned by cliché.

PAUL GRAHAM



‘End of an Age’ (1999) chronicles the pivotal juncture signifying the close of adolescence, encapsulating the threshold of youthful exuberance and the dawning realisation of adult responsibilities. There are both parallels and differences with my own project. Wasted On The Young looks at these same activities from a different time of change - between the end of youth and the start of old age. ‘End Of An Age’ stays away from the dancefloor, instead inhabiting the liminal spaces like corridors (stressing further the transitional state of the subjects) while this project concentrates on the escape that comes with dancing, alongside the calm moments away from the nightclub. One thing that seems to disappear is the uncertainty of the subjects of Graham’s work. The age that was “ending” was not just that of the subjects (and of what Graham calls “white western dominance”), but also for Graham. As he told i-D magazine: “I guess I was moving from being a younger photographer into mid-career... realising that my time in clubs and bars and staying up all night was ending.” This has parallels and opposes my own project – driven in part by my wish to rejoin the subjects on the dancefloor.

Graham’s deliberate use of varied lighting techniques further accentuates the essence of his narrative. The deployment of direct flash in the first part of the book, for instance, serves as an unforgiving revealer of details, forcing the viewer to confront and contemplate the subject in its rawest form – primarily their dilated pupils. But beyond mere revelation, the flash serves as a reminder of the photographer’s presence, making the act of capturing the image an intrinsic part of the narrative itself. This is something that forms a key part of my choice of on and off-camera flash. In essence, Graham’s work invites us into a rich discourse on temporality, transition, and transformation, themes that sit alongside my own project.

WOLFGANG TILLMANS



**‘FOR ME, A CLUB IS A BIG ABSTRACTION MACHINE THAT CONSTANTLY PRODUCES PICTURES. THEY’RE OFTEN ON THE EDGE OF THE VISIBLE, WHEN THE FOG RISES AND YOU LOOK UP TOWARD THE CEILING AND WATCH THE LIGHTS. INTANGIBLE THINGS SHIMMER AND FLICKER THROUGH THERE.’
TILLMANS (2019)**

Wolfgang Tillmans frequently shows his fascination with communal activities and club culture as potential alternatives to mainstream societal constructs. Though he cautions about the dangers of forced collectivity, he remains intrigued by non-commercial, self-organised activities operating outside the bounds of conventional controls – still photographing in nightclubs despite being in the centre of middle age. “It’s worth asking what choices you have if you don’t want to belong to the mainstream types of belonging in the privatised model of society – nation, sport, family values or religion,” he told Eichler (2008). Tillmans argues for the preservation of this spirit of community against a society increasingly leaning towards privatisation and commercialism. He prompts readers to question alternatives to traditional forms of belonging in today’s context.

As Cotton (2009) points out, his installations use his extensive collection of images as malleable elements, uniquely arranged and interconnected for each site. This rhythmic, almost musical, approach offers an immediate and immersive experience of his photography.

Tillman’s work in nightclubs is about the preservation of (frequently gay) spaces, about representation, about visibilities. While the spaces and people I am photographing aren’t threatened in the same way, I feel a similar desire to show middle-aged people existing in this world usually ringfenced for the young.



Research from The Centre for Ageing Better shows that age-related stereotypes influence perceptions about age, both in terms of viewing others and our self-awareness of ageing (Stuart, 2022) and imagery associated with ageing can shape these attitudes. They urge greater focus on visuals showcasing adults over 50 actively engaging in various activities in order to foster a more positive outlook towards them. The significance of such representation is profound. However, being age-positive requires authenticity. It's crucial to capture the diverse realities of ageing rather than just portraying an always-positive narrative.

Photographer unknown, Line Dancers, Centre For Ageing Better's age-positive image library

MARTIN PARR



Contemporary art photography still has a focus on youth, however, some photographers have tackled middle age. Martin Parr often finds the absurd in the middle-aged and focuses on that. The Englishness he finds on his home turf is that of the combover, the chintzy teacup and the garden party.

In 1991 MoMA's Pleasures & Terrors of Domestic Comfort a significant number of the featured individuals are of middle age. Taking their turn in the photographic spotlight were mothers and fathers – the middle-aged – engaged in homely activities like reading the paper at the kitchen table. However, given the exhibit was in 1991 and pulled from works perhaps a decade or two earlier, the representation of middle age from artists like Owens differs drastically from what I've captured, despite our subjects being of comparable ages. This divergence underscores a broader observation in photography: young individuals, the elderly, and middle-aged individuals are often portrayed in predefined, stereotypical ways.

BILL OWENS



TINA BARNEY



The representation of those in this demographic is one of being settled in life – not for them the excitement of the nightclub or the skate park.

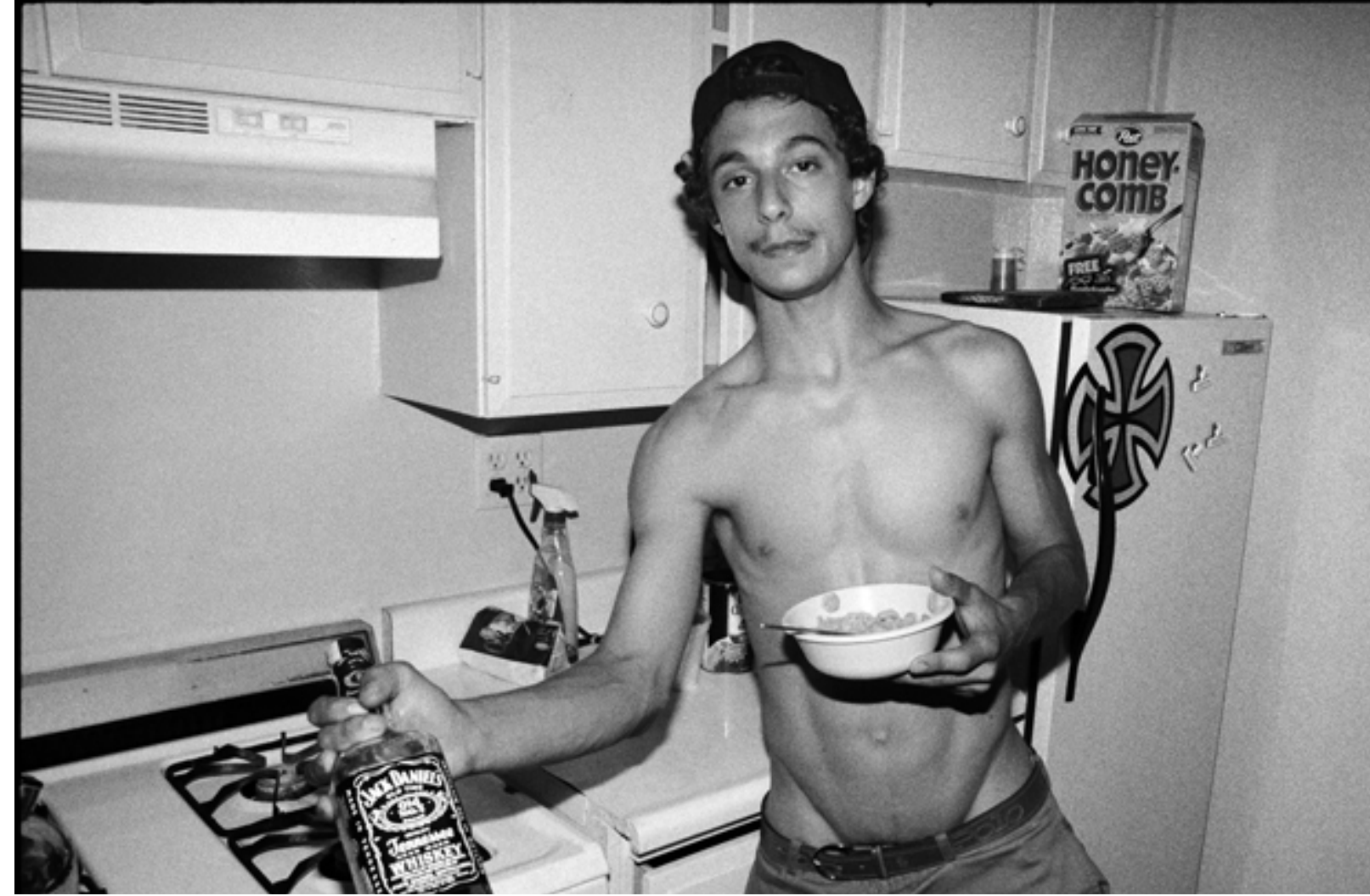
There exists a representation gap, particularly concerning middle-aged individuals partaking in certain activities. This gap, in essence, might be a reflection of our evolving world. Today's middle-aged population grew up amidst rave culture, which didn't exist for their predecessors. The lens through which they are viewed, therefore, should be distinct, capturing the unique zeitgeist of their era.

The project intends to portray the middle-aged in a manner that deviates from their conventional depiction, juxtaposing this with scenes from a quieter life away from the dance floor. Notable youth culture photographers, such as Ed Templeton, Larry Clark (in his "Tulsa" project), and Nan Goldin (in "The Ballad of Sexual Dependency"), have often portrayed the lives of young individuals and their tumultuous experiences within youth culture. Ryan McGinley's early work stands as a testament to this trend. Stylistically this work connects the subject to this visual history of youth culture, but replacing the chaos with calm.

RYAN MCGINLEY



ED TEMPLETON



The images in this project that diverge from the dancefloor setting may not immediately make their connection clear to the viewer. At times, they serve as subtle reflections or reminders of the dance scenes. In other instances, they symbolise typical middle-aged activities or home life. Some images might also act as metaphors for events on the dancefloor or depict moments from club life outside the club's confines. For instance, several photos capture the journey home after a night out, while others depict more traditional middle-aged pastimes, like country walks or visits to National Trust properties.

An example of this nuanced representation is a photo capturing wasps circling around an plate, taken at a National Trust property while enjoying a cream tea (the height of middle-aged life). While it may not be necessarily obvious what these counter photos are doing, they set a tone that I think is able to be navigated by people who are coming to the work fresh. The concept of allowing interpretative space for the audience was a gradual realisation for me. I delve deeper into this approach in the next section of the dossier.



STAGES OF RESEARCH PROCESS

STAGE 1: SCALE

In curating my work for Research Stage 1, I considered the potential of the transformative role of scale in photographic representation and how it impacts the viewer's experience, especially in work that is in the realm of documentary. My visit to Ewen Spencer's exhibition at Fabrica greatly informed this revelation. Spencer's images, primarily focused on fashion, also resonated with elements of youth culture. His use of intense flash, echoing the stylistic choices of photographers like Lauren Greenfield, struck a chord with me. More prominently, it was the expansive size of his prints that underscored my belief in the communicative power of scale in photography.

The act of enlarging photographs undeniably shifts their essence, ushering them into new conversational and interpretative spaces. In my own work, I've observed a distinct change when figures in photographs are displayed at a grander scale. Such presentation not only transforms individual images but also influences their dialogue with surrounding pieces. It's an evolving dance of meaning and interpretation, intricately tied to the display's size and viewer engagement.

My overarching aim was to fully immerse viewers within the photographic frame, echoing the sensations felt on a dancefloor, creating a deeply enveloping experience. I aspire for the images to resonate with the viewer, capturing the essence and emotion of the depicted scene, compelling them to feel 'in the midst' of it.

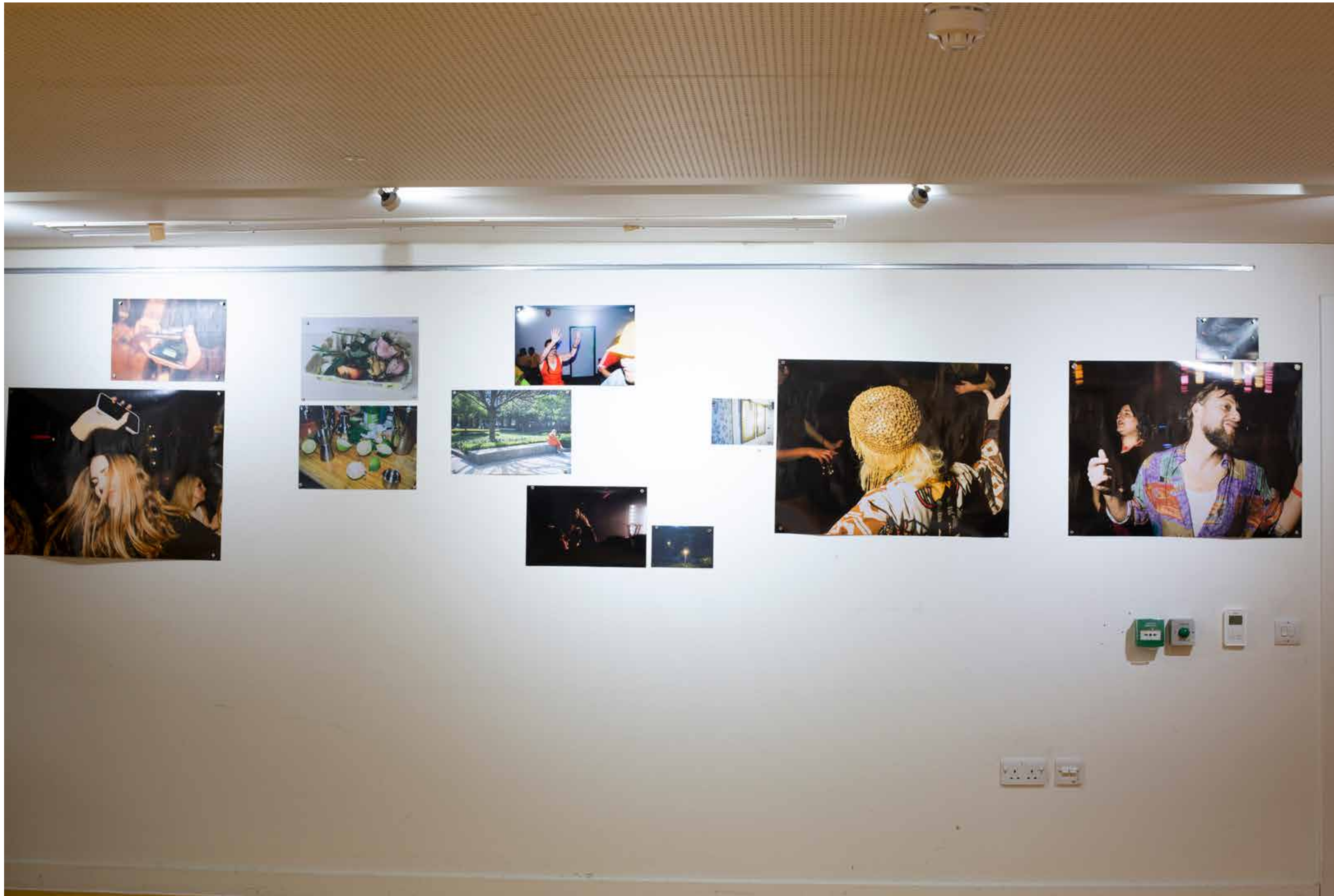
ALEX PRAGER / WOLFGANG TILLMANS



TODD HIDO / THOMAS STRUTH



STAGE 1 WORK



Furthermore, there's an inherent potency in printed photographs. These confined spaces, whether small or large, channel the viewer's focus, guiding their emotions and shaping their interpretations. It's crucial to understand and harness the potential of these defined boundaries to craft the desired impact.

For this stage, I opted for A1-sized prints for the wall. Utilising a digital medium format camera presented its own set of challenges. The camera technology, while advanced, was somewhat limiting in the environment I was working in due to its slow photographic process. Additionally, the heavy reliance on autofocus resulted in a notable number of misfocused images. While I do aim to embrace imperfections, especially in the book version of this project, many photos did not meet the desired quality. That said, the photos that were successfully captured resonated with my vision, especially in the larger format. What was less successful for this work was sizing down the photos, especially in contrast to the larger prints.

The high-resolution files suggest the possibility for even larger prints, potentially beyond A0, considering the viewer's distance. The exhibition showcased these images unrestrictedly, and the enlargement of certain pieces felt right. This approach certainly merits consideration for future exhibitions.



STAGE 2: MAKING ROOM FOR THE VIEWERS' NARRATIVE

In my reflections, I realised the importance of granting viewers the autonomy to derive meaning, ensuring space for creative interpretation. My initial approach in this project up to this point may have been too prescriptive, potentially overshadowing the viewer's opportunity to explore and interpret the work organically.

Viewers often interpret photographs through a “multisensual” lens, integrating intellectual, visual, public, and private memories rooted in identity and location (Hughes & Noble, 2003). Burgin (1982) emphasizes the viewer's mental participation, with photographs serving as catalysts for thought. The richer a viewer's personal context, the more profound their connection to the image. Barthes (1982) distinguishes between the ‘studium’ (expected subject) and the ‘punctum’ (personal emotional response). Bate (2020) opines that a single photo lacks an intrinsic narrative; instead, viewers superimpose their own experiences.

The juxtaposition between raw, striking images and the calmer, contemplative environmental shots can be discerned, especially in what is primarily perceived as documentary work. Such a term,



GREGORY HALPERN



while accurate for numerous works, doesn't fully encompass the scope of photographers like Alec Soth. His photos are not merely about recording; they're an inventive exploration of places and ideas grounded in reality. They aim to transform the subject, something I aimed for in my own works. Many of the photographers whose work I find most engaging take this approach, even within a documentary aesthetic. Their work can evolve into a more lyrical form, presenting photographs in a way that encourages broader interpretation, moving beyond just the subject at hand.

Photography subtly hints at messages rather than directly conveying them, whereas the written word can transmit messages more explicitly but struggles with pure description compared to images. Soth (2010) highlights that photographs, being frozen moments in time, are not adept at storytelling in the traditional sense. "Photographs aren't good at telling stories. Stories require a beginning, middle and end. They require the progression of time. Photographs stop time," he says. Instead, they excel in suggesting narratives. Their ability to insinuate stories makes them potent tools in advertising and propaganda, offering the allure of ideal lifestyles or supporting specific agendas. The fleeting nature of a photograph, captured in a split second, cannot fully encapsulate the broader context.

Gregory Halpern emphasises the distinction between pure documentation and artistic creation, noting that

CURRAN HATLEBERG



his motivations lean more towards moulding the observed realities in alignment with his vision. He argues against the notion of objective documentary work, viewing it as not only misleading but also undermining the viewer's ability to engage and interpret. The joy in art, according to Halpern, lies in the active interpretation by its audience. "One of the great pleasures of looking at art is in being an active reader, in piecing together the meaning of the work," he says (2013). He is critical of his early work, believing it to be too prescriptive, stifling open interpretation.

Larry Sultan emphasises the significance of ambiguity in his work. He believes that due to the rich representational history of most subjects, finding a fresh perspective is challenging for photographers. For Sultan, a well-defined narrative risks becoming merely illustrative, which lacks appeal both for the creator and the viewer. Straddling the line between the ordinary and the surreal is where he finds the desired tension. "that ambiguity and that play between the ordinary and the surreal or the extraordinary is really the edge that I'm hoping for," he says (from an interview with Ben R. Sloat, April 2008, reprinted 2015). Such images don't instantly command attention due to dramatic elements, but their subtlety invites prolonged contemplation, pushing the viewer to discern the nuances.

Sean O'Hagan (2022) notes that Curran Hatleberg captures a sense of place that is more imaginative than geographical. Hatleberg distances himself from labels such as "documentary photographer" and "road photographer," finding them limiting or inaccurate. When he works, the camera serves as an evident

STAGE 2 WORK



tool, often diminishing the distance between him and the subject. Rather than starting with a preconceived narrative, Hatleberg often shapes the story and meaning post-shooting. This approach results in images, like those in ‘River’s Dream,’ that are atmospheric and enigmatic. For Hatleberg, the depth of the artwork is inherently linked to the depth of the experience behind it.

As someone who has come from written journalism, where the idea is to transmit information as clearly as possible in the most direct and succinct way, coming to this realisation that photography frequently benefits from leaving room for the viewer to make their own readings has been hard fought, and one of the most valuable lessons in this course and in the production of this work.

I think the project really came into its own when I was able to provide a counterpoint to the more direct clubbing pictures that left room for viewer interpretation. This strand of the project is equally appealing to me, and I enjoy making this work perhaps more than the clubbing pictures. Many of these pictures start to provide value to the project only when given time and attention in the editing process and it’s only through sequencing that they really settle into the overall project.

DEJA VIEW



STAGE 3: SEQUENCING

During the project, I grappled with challenges but achieved significant breakthroughs when sequencing the images. By displaying them on a wall, I found clarity amidst the plethora of photos.

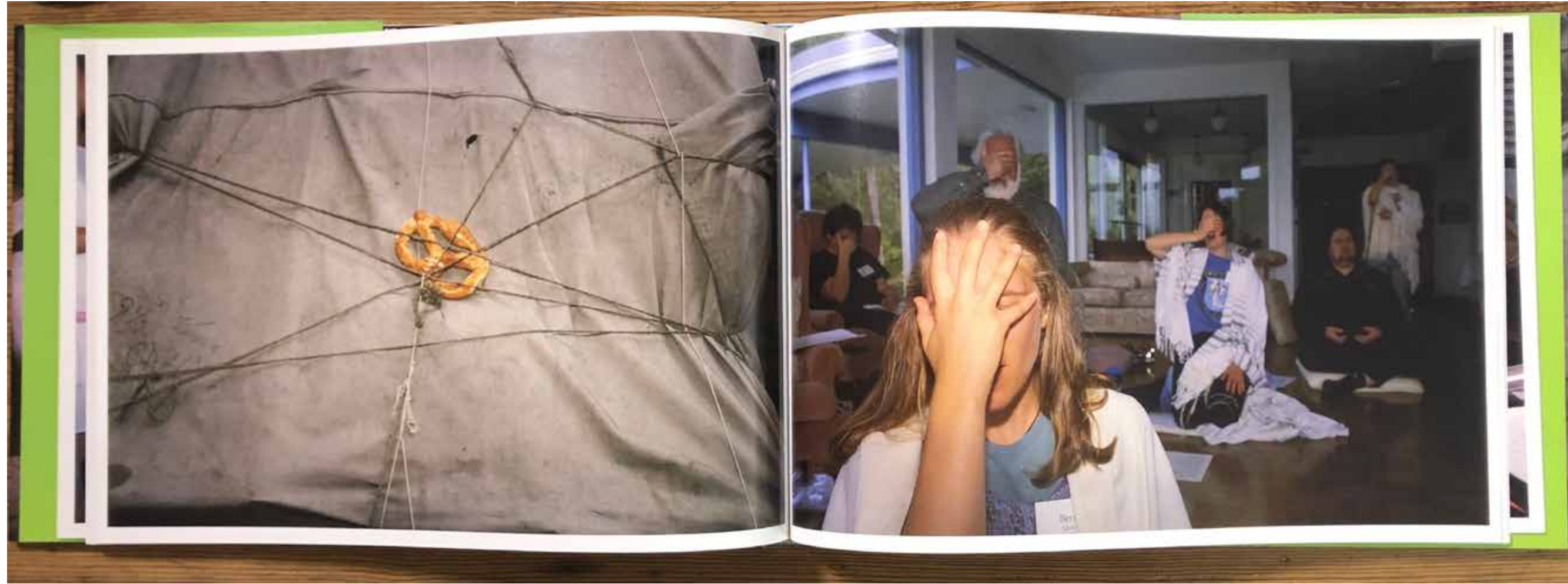
My realisation deepened through bookmaking. Initially, creating a zine helped me pair images. Martin Parr's collaboration with The Anonymous Project for "Deja View", sequenced by Lee Shulman, exemplified this pairing technique, blending two distinct stories seamlessly.

The "20twenty" catalogue from the Frankel Gallery was illuminating. It sequenced varied photographers' works, with themes ranging from typography to the human form. One memorable sequence juxtaposed Atget's headless mannequins with a John Gutmann photo of a subject's head hidden by the stuts of a pier, and then Diane Arbus' sword-swallowing circus act, demonstrating a poetic flow between singular images.

Paul Graham's "New Europe", political in nature, subtly juxtaposed colours, shapes, and ideas. Despite some images being less clear as to their intent, the collective feel conveyed Graham's intent, and I kept returning to the book to make more sense of it.



NO TITLE HERE



COMMON SENSE



Jeff Mermelstein’s “No Title Here” was another influential reference, celebrating the absurd with paired images and emphasising the incidental. His style resonates with renowned photographers like Garry Winogrand and Diane Arbus, blending humanism with quirky humour.

Martin Parr’s “Common Sense” presented a vivid visual connection between paired yet disparate images. This visual onslaught paired a vicar’s collar with an Irish cola bottle, and pig-faced cupcakes with a sunburnt elderly man.

Sequencing helped me identify standalone images and groups, culminating in a triptych for my exhibition. This point clarified the project’s essence, encapsulated within these three images. Given our limited exhibition space, I refined my project’s core message and the minimal images required to convey it. Although the project’s extensive scope enhanced it, I’ve learned to extract specific images to communicate distinct narratives as needed.

The lessons I learned through the sequencing of the work have really cemented for me what this project is about, and have given me the tools to take it further.

This feels like a point for evaluation rather than an endpoint. And this project probably has several years of picture making before it reaches its completion.

However, I am happy with where the project currently runs, and look forward to adding more to it over the coming years. In the meantime, I believe there’s enough work here to present sections for exhibition, or to make small publications that lead to a greater piece of work down the line.



STAGE 3 WORK



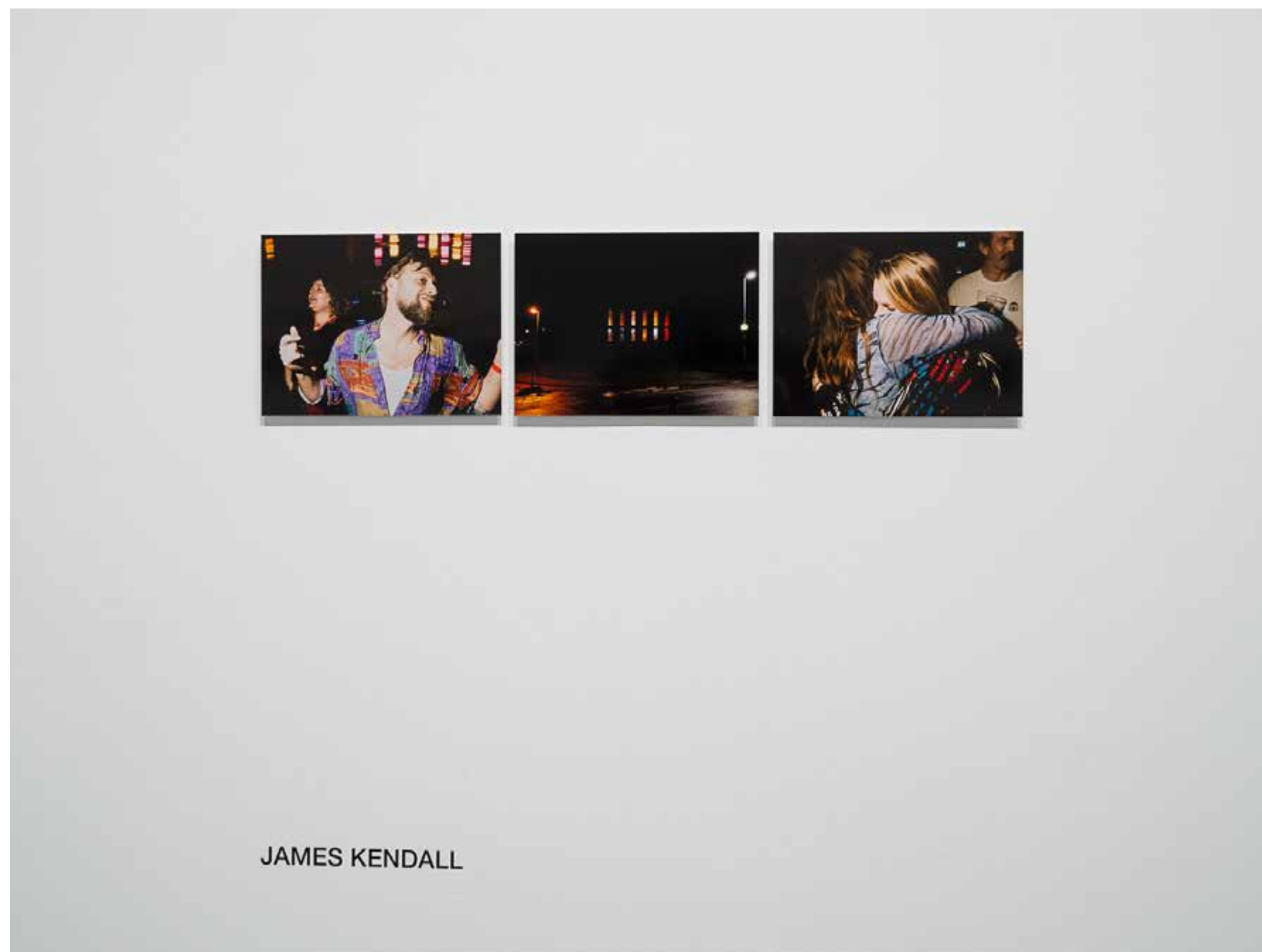
STAGE 3 WORK



STAGE 3 WORK



EXHIBITION VIEWS (TO BE CONSIDERED FOR L04)



The realisation of work for the exhibition featured C-Type prints on Canson high gloss paper, sized at 38mm x 29mm, mounted on dibond.

While the high gloss printing offers the deep blacks and rich saturation the work requires, it comes with the disadvantage of being easily susceptible to damage. However, I believe the aesthetic value compensates for the potential imperfections that might appear on the prints.

I'm grateful to have had the support of the University printing department, ensuring each print was immaculate and free of defects.

Due to spatial constraints within the exhibition area, the placement of the three images in close proximity became necessary. This configuration formed a very direct triptych, reinforcing the narrative the images aimed to convey and drawing overt connections between them.

For future exhibitions, I'm inclined to opt for larger prints to enhance their impact. Yet, at their current size, they sufficiently capture the essence of both the vibrant dancefloor and the serene ambiance of the church. The proximity of these prints seemed to invite viewers to delve deeper into the recurring visual themes and to spend time to consider the subtler, more tranquil image and its connection to the more direct clubbing photos.

Moving forward, I plan to maintain the use of high gloss C-Type prints. The dimensions will be adapted based on the exhibition space, but I'm keen on ensuring they are no smaller than the current size, with a preference for larger prints to provide a more enveloping experience.



James Kendall,
Untitled, Wasted
On The Young,
2022-2023, 29mm
x 38mm, C-Type
prints on Canson
high gloss paper



James Kendall,
Untitled, Wasted
On The Young,
2022-2023, 29mm
x 38mm, C-Type
prints on Canson
high gloss paper



James Kendall,
Untitled, Wasted
On The Young,
2022-2023, 29mm
x 38mm, C-Type
prints on Canson
high gloss paper



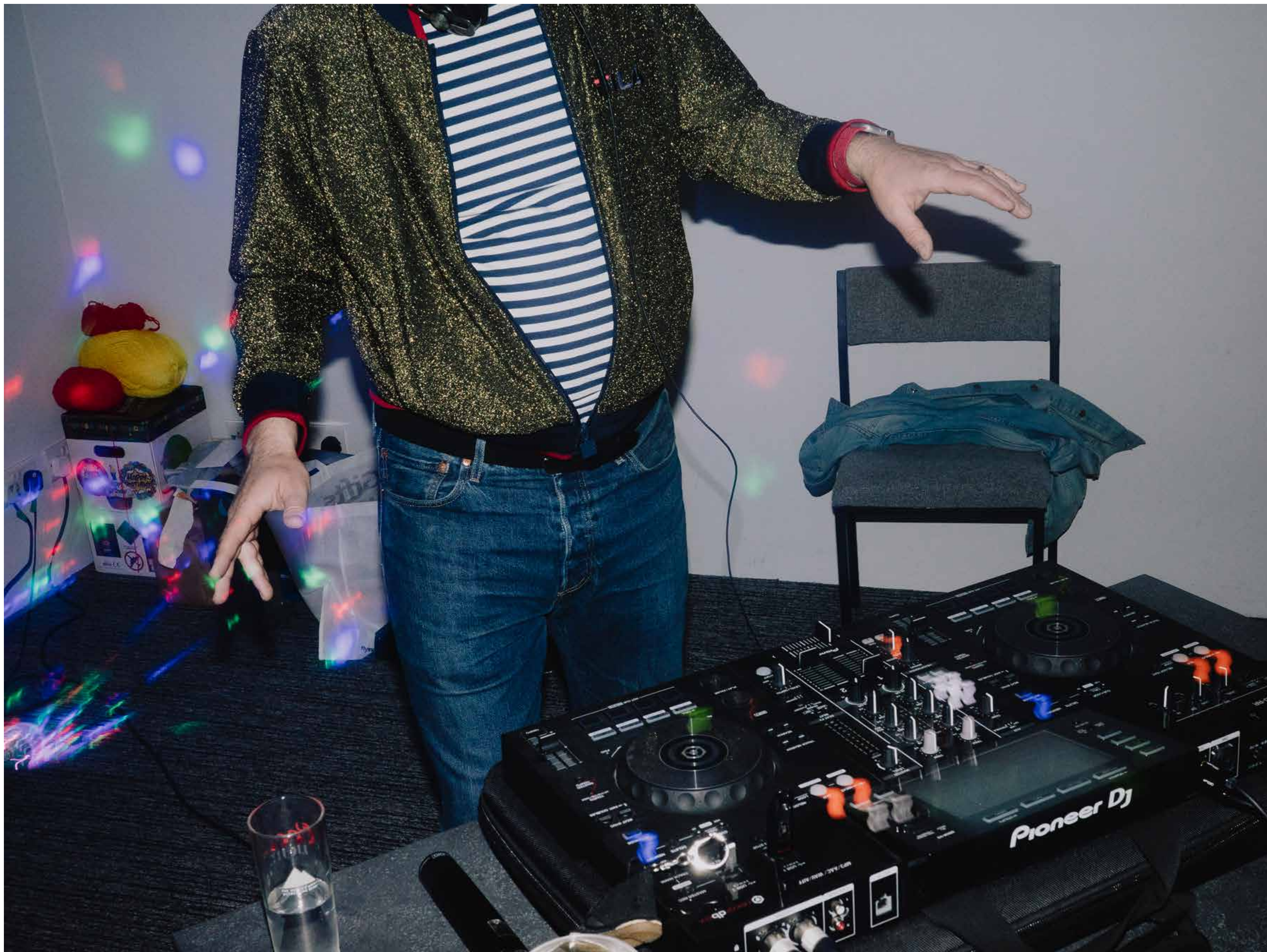
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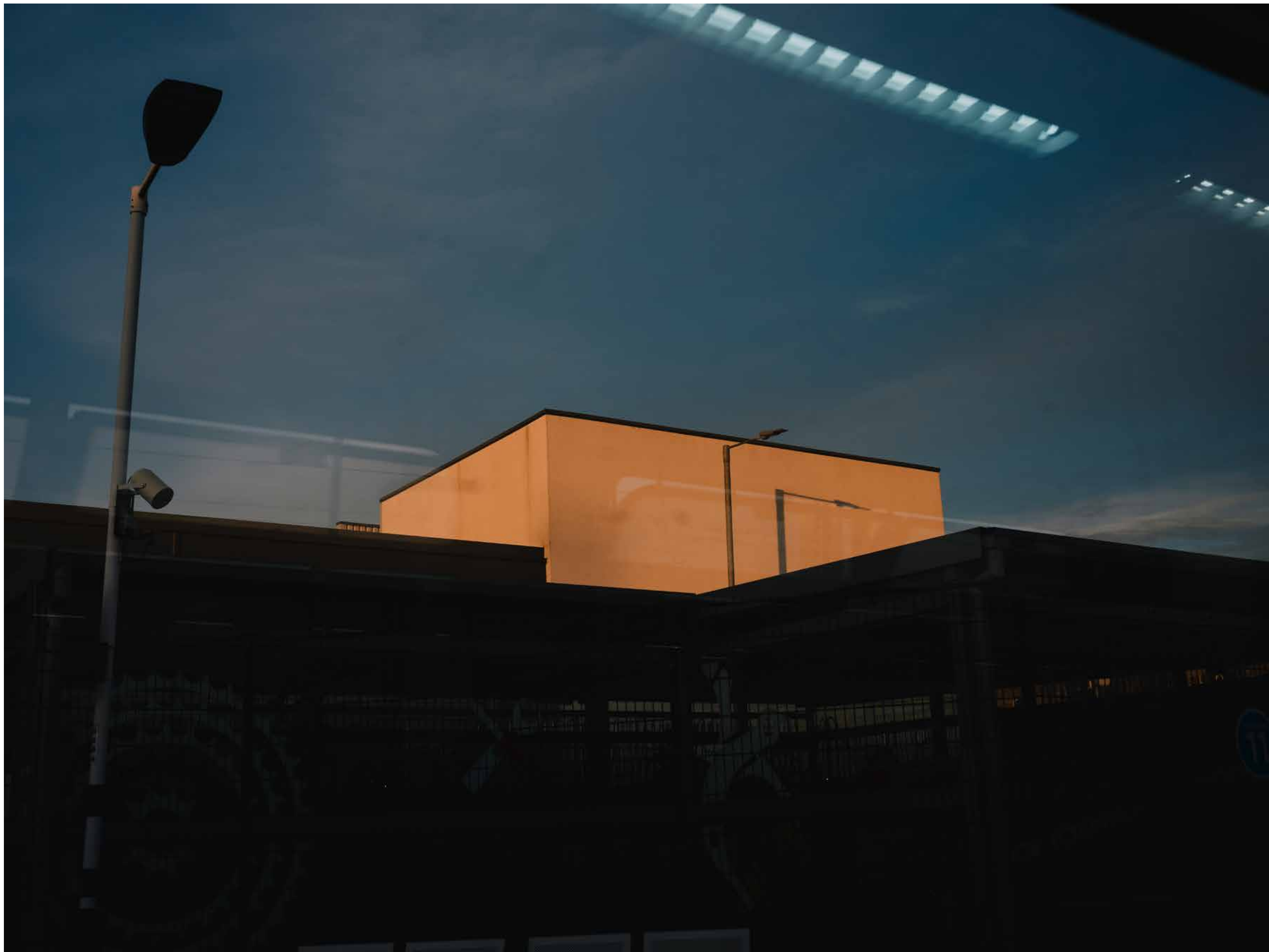
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YOUTH CULTURE & MIDDLE AGE

It's not unusual for someone that grew up during the early days of rave culture to consider it the defining moment of their lives. Evidence of this is visible under the dance track videos uploaded to YouTube, where men of a certain age (it's almost exclusively men) relive their best days in the comments. As far back as 2013, Vice's Clive Martin recognised the wholesomeness of this community, an outpouring of 'good vibes'. Such was the cultural impact of these comments that Twitter accounts sprung up to collect up the best, and Bicep made a lauded, emotionally resonating music video around them (2017's Glue).

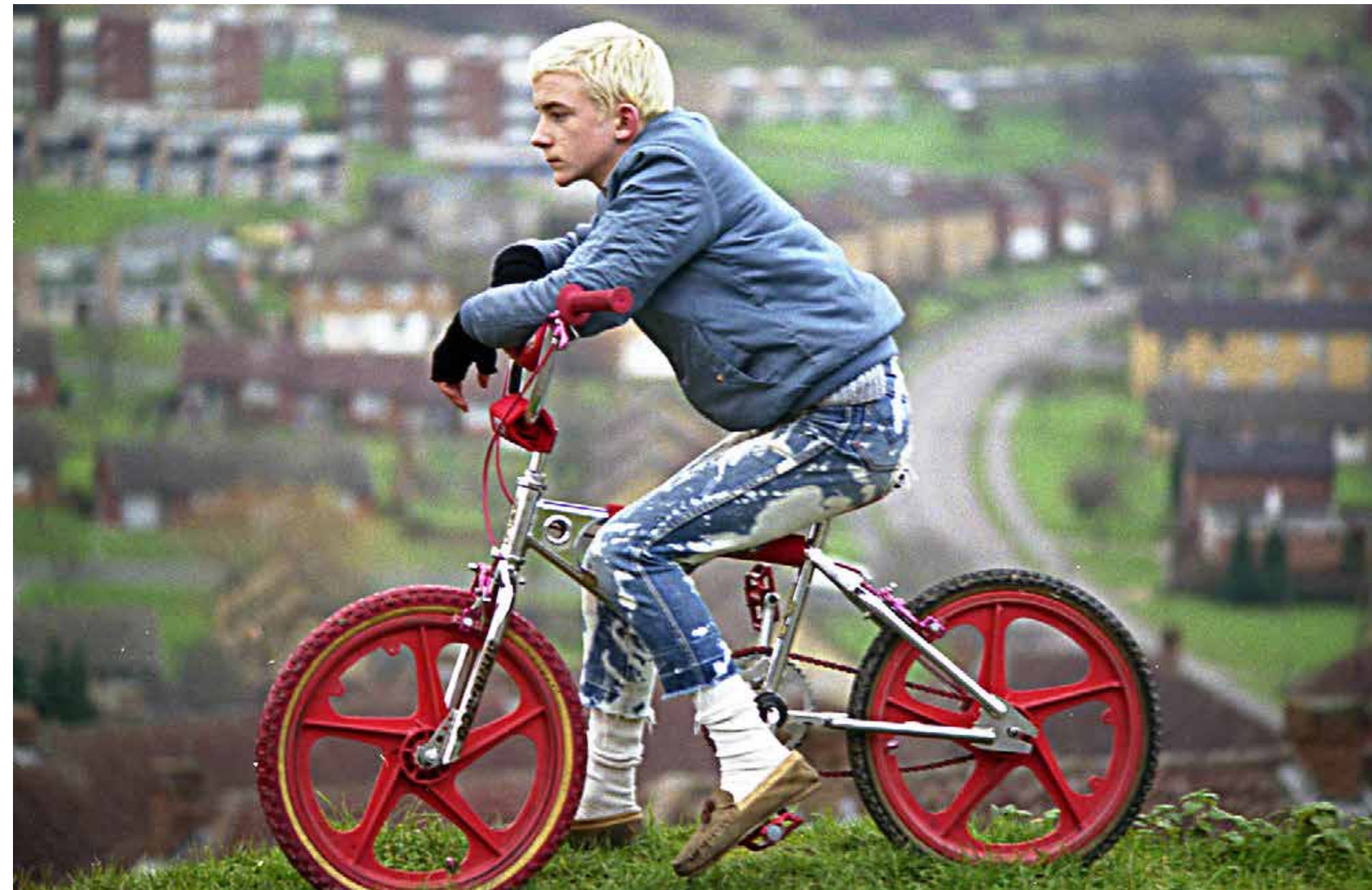
Someone who was 18 when the Second Summer of Love hit Britain would be 53 this year. Someone who was 30 then would be drawing their pension. Our middle-aged population is made up of a group of people that – if it aligned with their musical taste – could have been dancing all night at illegal and legal parties. Parallels to the 60s run rife in these YouTube comments, with many saying that actually it's the young ravers that were born at just the right moment, not the flower children. So, if we still expect to see older music fans at heritage gigs by the likes of Bob Dylan and The Rolling Stones, should we not also expect to see ravers on the dancefloor dancing to Altern-8 and Danny Rampling.

However, there can be stigma around older music fans dancing. "New research has revealed 37 is the age we are officially "too old" to be seen a nightclub," declared the Yorkshire Post in 2017. While continuing their outward support of aging ravers, Vice's documentary of "Gravers" rolled out a handful of extreme characters to show how never leaving club culture can damage you. I intend for Wasted On The Young to counteract this narrative and show people gaining joy from youth culture. The people in Wasted On The Young are not concerned with nostalgia or recreating their youth, but are a strata of people that have never left the youth culture space. Not for them the heritage nights of 80s one hit wonders, or the Oasis tribute acts. Though some would criticise them for not moving on from the passions of their youth, they have found themselves a place in the world by staying interested in the new things those worlds have to offer.



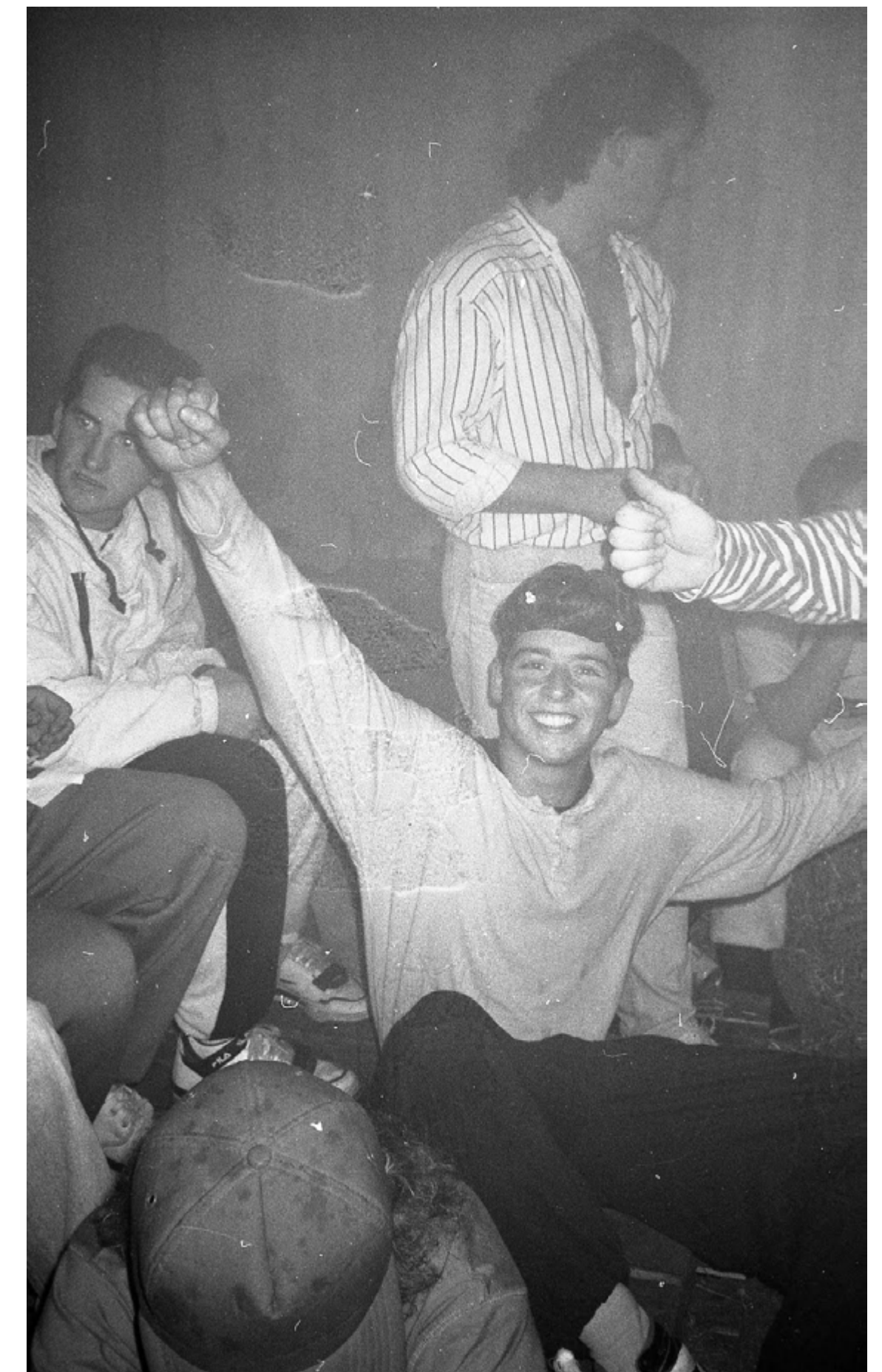
-  **@markpeters3193** 1 year ago
49 and still stuck in 92 please help me !! Still goose bumps play everyday and want back there
 153  Reply
-  **@davidmckennedy** 9 years ago
We need to bring it all back! Top nights and early mornings. The times made me who I am today and I'm proud to say I was a part of a massive cultural movement! What's your name? Where are you from? What have you had? SORTED!!!
 2  Reply
-  **@mikemanders4902** 6 years ago
gram of pink champagne 2 phase 4s and I am ready to shake my old ass once again...classic tune !
 35  Reply

YOUTH CULTURE



GAVIN WATSON

Gavin Watson is a great example of the photographing from the inside. Despite – or perhaps cause of – a lack of formal training when many of his most famous images were made, he is able to capture meaningful moments from a group of people that would put up barriers many photographers.



ZED NELSON



MICHAEL SCHMIDT





DANIEL CRONIN



DANIELLE LEVITT



CORRINE DAY



PAUL GRAHAM



PAUL REAS



ANNA FOX



CLUBBING & YOUTH CULTURE IN THE ART SPACE



JUERGEN TELLER

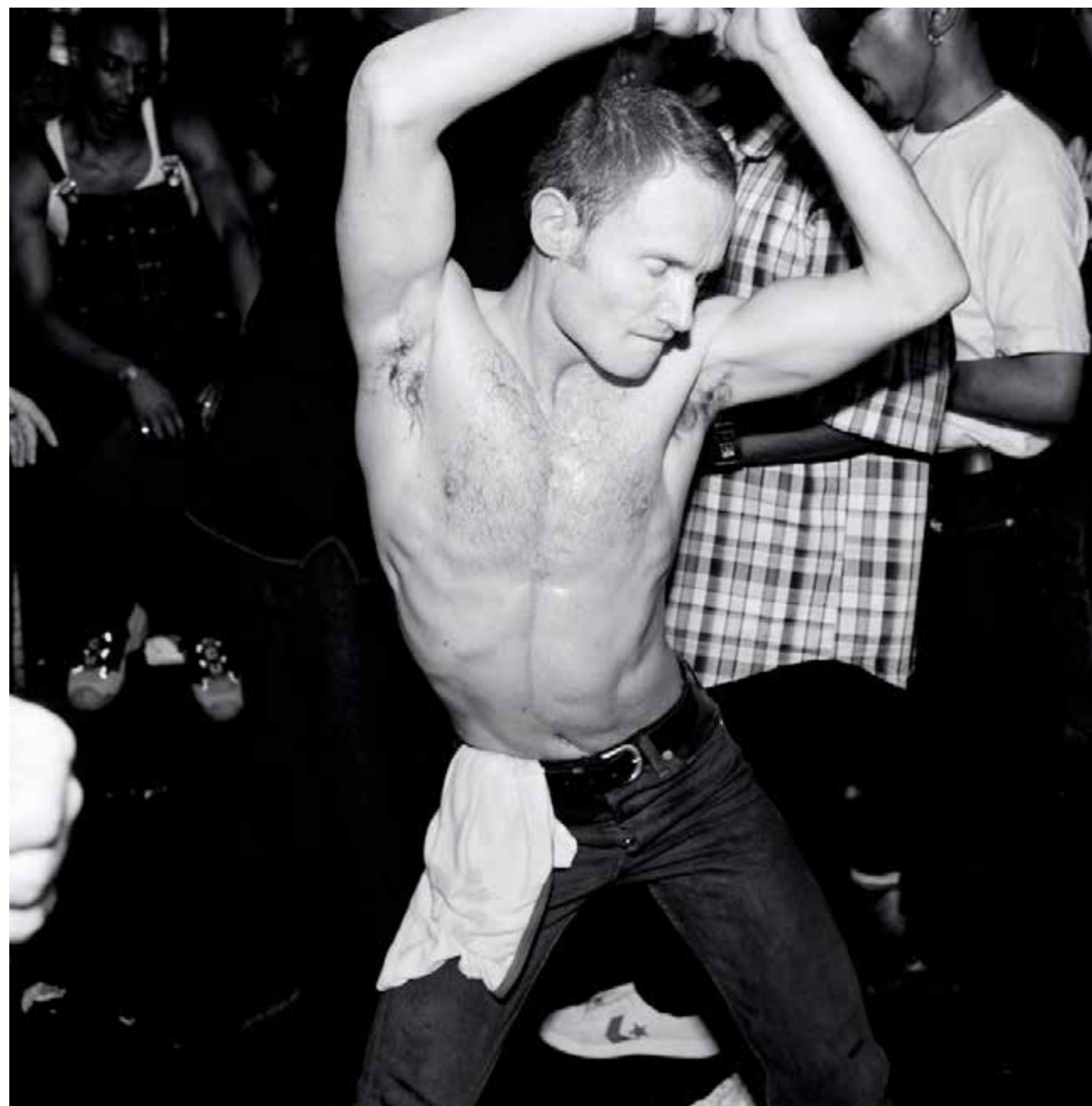


RINEKE DIJKSTRA



Rineke Dijkstra (1997) “Often people find my images merciless or pitiless, while in fact I’m trying to achieve just the opposite, the feeling that as a viewer you can almost get inside someone’s skin, and that you can identify with them. Without mystification.”

EWEN SPENCER



EWEN SPENCER

The use of flash ties Wasted On Young to the style magazine photographers, skateboard photographers and artists straddling the fashion and art worlds. The two photographers that have most influenced the look of these photos are Ewen Spencer and Elaine Considine. Their use of hard flash to freeze the body in motion and bring colour into their images (Spencer worked in black and white for Sleaze Nation) is something that I adopted in order to capture the energy I was finding in the space. Spencer balances the naturalistic and the contrived in both his fashion work and his club pictures, making a hyper real world that invites us in. According to his collaborator Olivia Gideon Thompson in their interview for Photoworks (2016), Spencer – a middle aged man – is always looking for the next thing in youth culture.

ELAINE CONSIDINE



Elaine Considine brings a documentary feel to her fashion work, and her upbringing through the northern soul scene seems to give her a connection to movement that transfers easily to the photograph. Brook McCord of *The Face* (2021) describes her active photoshoots: “Constantine waits until her models are dancing, cycling, shouting, wrestling, screaming or getting drunk to push the shutter, and it’s this sense of fearlessness that gives her work a rare authenticity.”

DOUGIE
WALLACE



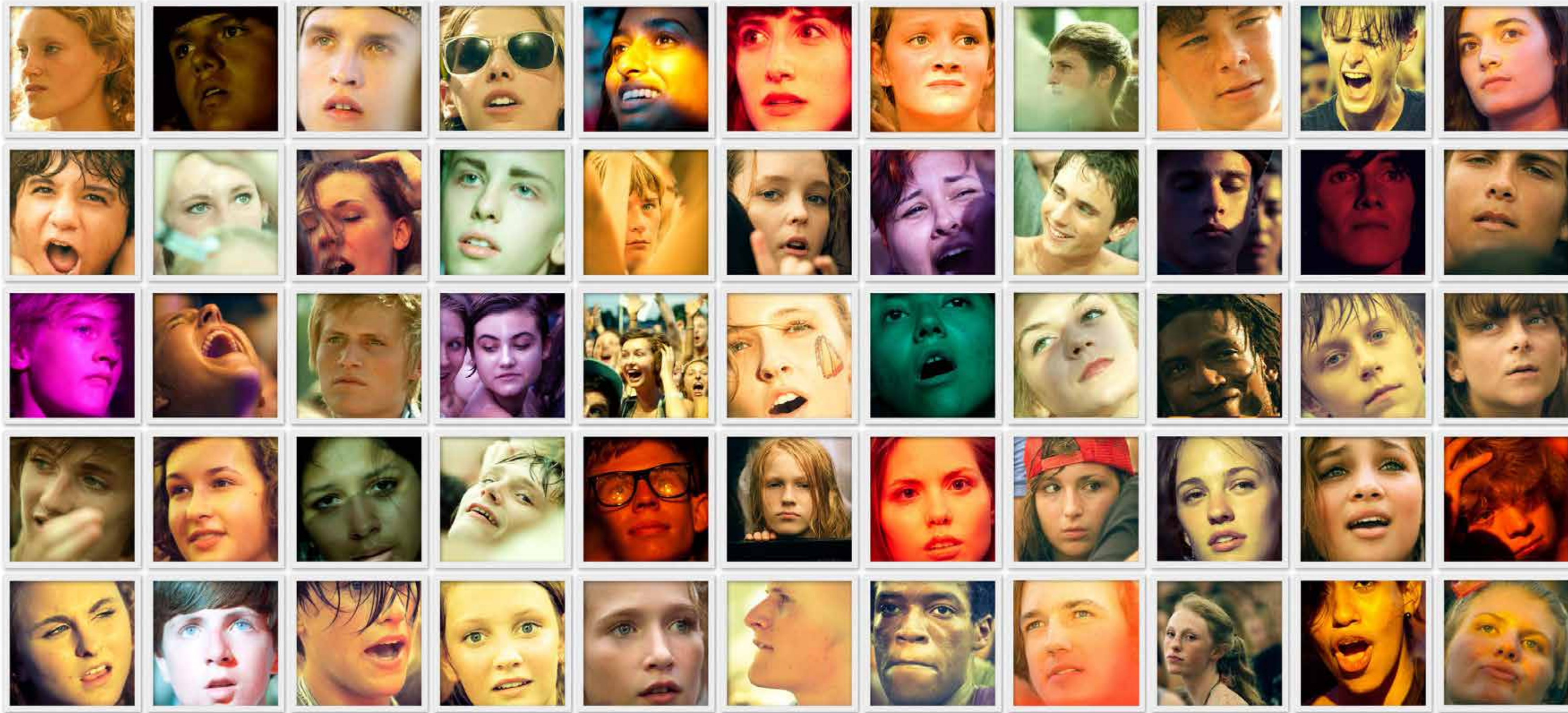
LAUREN
GREENFIELD





RYAN MCGINLEY

In addition to his road trip celebrating youth, McGinley toured with Morrissey taking photos of the crowd.



RICHARD AVEDON



MARIO TESTINO



**THE BODY IN
MOVEMENT**



JACQUES HENRI LARTIGUE



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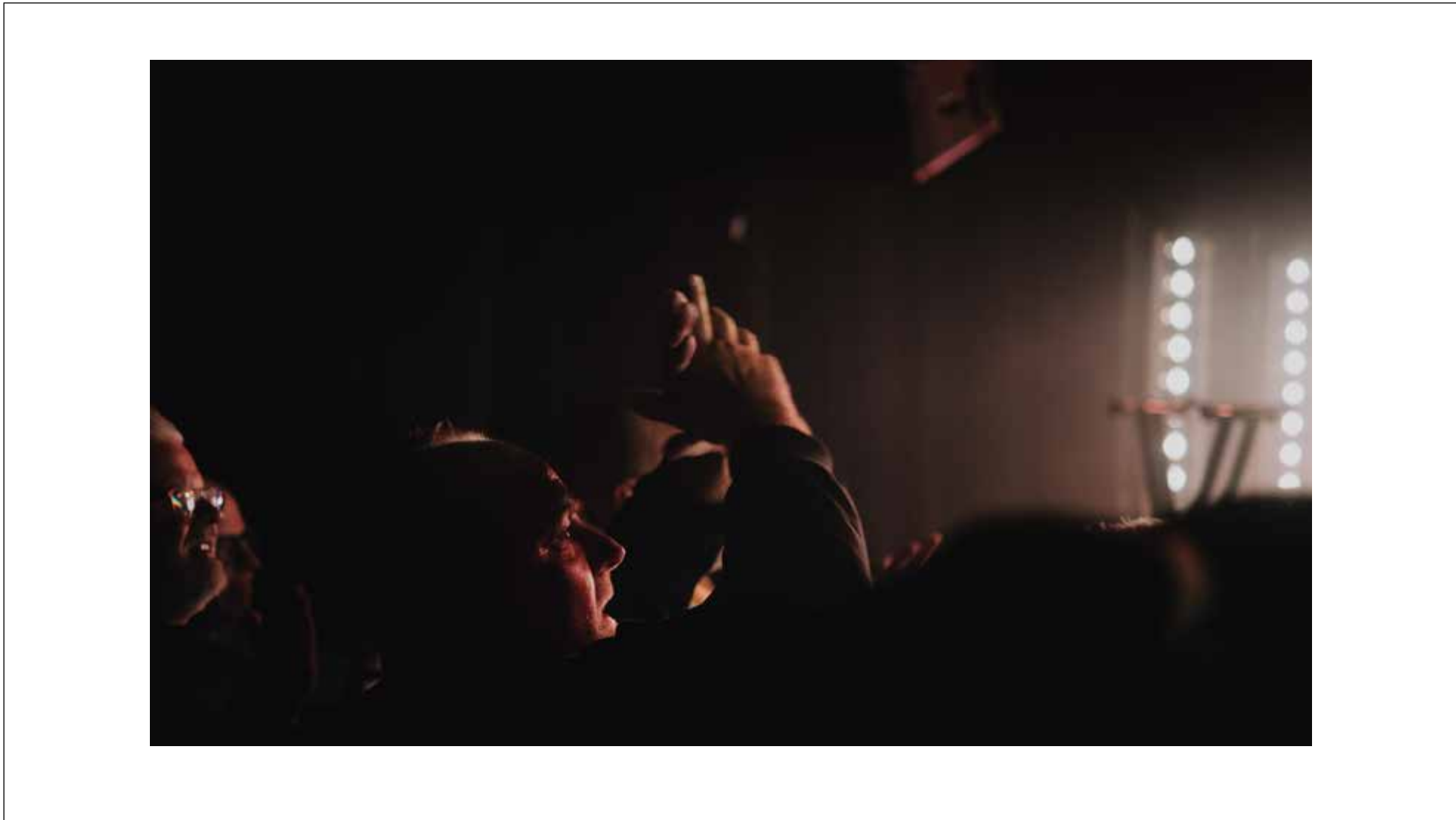
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Bill Owens, Leisure (1979)





40-Something-Year Old Man's Entire Identity Based on Two-Year Span from His 20s



Facebook

Twitter

Reddit

BY JEFF CARDIELLO / OCTOBER 18, 2020

PHOENIX — 40-something-year-old Jason Deluca has reportedly based his entire personality and lifestyle around a two-year period of his 20s in



Elaine Considine. 3.45. The Face. 1999



Martin Parr (2023): "I always think it's my duty as a photographer to try and entice the viewer in with a brightly coloured picture. And then if there's any meaning behind it, that's later to be found, if you so desire. If people just like the pretty colours I'm quite happy."



Photographer unknown, date unknown



Any Questions?



Project Overview

Wasted On The Young

- The project reflects personal experiences and challenges societal norms of aging.
- Aims to portray middle-aged individuals maintaining their passions, defying traditional aging stereotypes.
- Seeks to illustrate that life at 50 is not as younger generations imagine.
- Advocates the idea that everyone retains a youthful spirit, perpetually 24 at heart.

Themes

- The work embraces the idea of multiple meanings - but these are a few of the themes for me:
- Social connection
- Joy
- The body as a communicator of emotion
- Photography as a means to connect with the world
- Photography as identity forming
- The changing nature of middle age

Representations Of Middle Age In The Media

- The Meldrew Point is 53 years old. Jay-Z recently hit the Meldrew Point.
- Sitcom dads, invisible women and midlife crisis
- Gatlin et al: "The (over)reactions of a middle-aged person to the realisation that they are no longer "young" provide bountiful opportunities for humorous plots and scenarios. Inter-generational tensions, in the form of jibes from younger people, can contribute to the age-related anxieties exhibited by middle aged characters."
- Traditional music discourse often overlooks mature audience, focusing on the youth.
- Roz, 49, "Middle age is actually a fantastic place to be. It's just the judgmental attitudes towards it that are depressing."

Middle Age In Photography

- Despite their common representation in photography, middle-aged, white, middle-class music fans rarely see their leisurely activities reflected.
- Culture, especially photography, typically portrays aging as unattractive (Copeland, 1994).
- Bill Owens' Leisure (1979) depicts middle-aged party attendees seated, not actively engaging.
- Martin Parr's work showcases aging signs rather than vibrant nightlife.
- Larry Sultan's "Pictures From Home" (1992) presents an early retiree, far from the clubbing scene.

Social Media & The Visibility Of Middle Age

- Highlights the changing role of technology and social media's impact on personal visibility perceptions.
- Younger generations, having grown up with social media, are more conscious of their online representation, influencing their behaviours and photo presentations.
- In contrast, the subjects, who didn't experience their formative years with social media, show more freedom and willingness to be photographed.
- Discusses how the evolving social presence of the camera over time influences people's reactions to being photographed.
- People exhibit willingness to be photographed while dancing, possibly due to lowered inhibitions or a desire to appear "photograph-worthy".

Youth Culture As Identity Formation

- My personal identity shaped by photographs and magazine images from mid-teens.
- Started with skateboarding magazines, progressed to music press, and then style magazines like The Face in the 90s.
- Exposure to works of Juergen Teller, Elaine Considine, and Corinne Day.
- Personal exploration includes returning to image-makers that helped in identity curation.

Youth Culture As Identity Formation

- Individuals who experienced the early rave culture often view it as life-defining.
- Evidence is seen in YouTube comments under dance track videos where mostly men nostalgically recall their past.
- Vice's Clive Martin recognised this wholesomeness and positive energy as early as 2013.
- Cultural impact led to Twitter accounts showcasing top comments and influenced Bicep's music video "Glue" (2017).

Nostalgia Vs Engagement

- "Wasted On The Young" aims to counteract negative narratives, showcasing individuals finding joy in youth culture.
- Subjects are not nostalgia-driven, but part of a group consistently engaged in youth culture.
- Instead of attending tribute acts or heritage nights, they remain interested in new cultural offerings.
- Although some might criticise their enduring youthful passions, these individuals find fulfilment in staying current.
- The project is more interested in continuous cultural engagement than nostalgia.

The Changing Nature Of Middle Age

- Individuals who were 18 during the Second Summer of Love would now be 53; 30-year-olds from that time would now be retired.
- This middle-aged demographic could have experienced all-night dancing at both legal and illegal parties, if aligned with their music taste.
- YouTube comments reveal parallels between the 60s and rave era, suggesting the younger ravers were born at the right time, not just the 60s' "flower children".
- Just as we expect older music fans at heritage gigs, e.g., Bob Dylan and The Rolling Stones, we should anticipate seeing mature ravers at dance events, like Altern-8 and Danny Rampling.

The Stigma Of The Aging Clubber

- Stigma exists around older music fans dancing.
- Research in 2017 suggested 37 is deemed "too old" for nightclub appearances (Yorkshire Post).
- Despite supporting aging ravers, Vice's "Gravers" documentary highlighted potential damages of never leaving club culture through extreme character examples.

Different Reactions Per Age Bracket

- Really strong reaction to previews on social media from people in their middle age (including Gavin Watson and Sian Davey)
- One younger commenter said the photos were tinged with an element "lameness" –these people haven't, like, moved on, they're still doing the thing that they were doing when they were young.

Centre for Ageing Better: "If we see photos of adults aged 50+ enjoying their older age, for example socialising, exercising or working, people will naturally start to view older people in a more positive and considered way. The impact of this kind of representation cannot be underestimated."

Diversity

- Hope to empower other people to document their own communities
- As a white man it's interesting to work out where to place myself as an ally without stamping on other communities stories
- There are black, gay people in this body of work, but it isn't its focus to
- My primary focus is the representation of different age groups in photography and the complexities of visibility of those groups.

Style Magazines

- Introduction to influential photographers like Corinne Day, Juergen Teller, Elaine Considine, and Ewen Spencer through these style magazines.
- Began curating a world of personal identity through collected magazine shoots
- Importance of full bleed, colour images in shaping the "Wasted On The Young" project.
- Colour plays a vital role in the work, particularly in music space photos, enhancing the vibrancy and activity.
- Use of flash and open shutter technique captures motion and floods the picture with washes of colour from lights.
- While it references the snapshot aesthetic, the technique is not intended to be an artless document or invisible picture-making process (Bate, 2015).

Shooting From The Inside

- As Goldin (1986) says, "I'm not crashing; this is my party."
- Gavin Watson is an influence in the value of the photographing from the inside – able to capture meaningful moments from a group of people that would put up barriers
- Being part of the crowd is essential for capturing genuine reactions to the music, rather than posed photos.
- Filling the frame to mimic the sensation of being immersed in the action.
- Shooting aims not to disrupt the experience, observing how people tolerate cameras and flash in different contexts.
- Use of flash places the photographer, and the process of photography, visibly in the photos.

Colour

Martin Parr (2023): "I always think it's my duty as a photographer to try and entice the viewer in with a brightly coloured picture. And then if there's any meaning behind it, that's later to be found, if you so desire. If people just like the pretty colours I'm quite happy."

Accessibility Through Aesthetics

- Charlotte Cotton: it is “personal experience which unlocks a piece of art” for a potential audience
- Adding that the academic context need to engage with much contemporary art can be a barrier.
- Wasted On The Young attempts to be a project that lets people in. While not everyone has skateboarded, most people have felt the abandon of dancing, or experienced a passion as a young person that they might want to reconnect with.
- But even if the viewer doesn't connect with that reading, there is joy and community running through the pictures

Leaving Space For The Viewer

- A concern for the work has been how to move it away from purely documentary, or editorial
- But it is in part those things, it's certainly informed by them.
- The limitations of photography vs words
- Photography's strength is to hint at a narrative. It can suggest emotion but the written word will always transmit messages more directly.

Realisation

- Reference to pages in magazines
- Like the photos you'd get back from your film camera
- Gloss, full bleed, unframed
- Scale - immersive, inviting viewers into the picture and making them feel as if they are part of the scene
- The rich colours heighten the feelings the vibrancy of the activity.
- While this all gives reference to the snapshot – the memories of a night out recorded on cheap film cameras and printed on 5x7” paper – it is not intended to be an artless document, one that makes the picture making invisible (Bate, 2015).

Printed Form & Future Directions

- Series of interconnected zines
- Articles
- Interviews & video
- Music

WASTED ON THE YOUNG

OVERVIEW

Wasted On The Young is in service to the understanding of the intersection of aging, youth culture and identity. In line with my previous projects, it uses photography's power to connect, here to re-engage with various obsessions of my past that were once the building blocks of my persona. As we slip quietly into middle age, many of us find ourselves adrift, life in the home taking over from communal obsessions that drove us as adolescents. The subjects of these photographs have found a space in their lives to stay connected to the parts of themselves that felt meaningful at 17, 25, 31 (the age when most give up on clubbing). This is a celebration of the continued connection to meaningful activities, a recognition of the effort it takes to step away from the screen and stop doom scrolling.

The broader body of work, from which this second stage will be drawn, builds on the initial chapter which selected images that used the body in space as a means to communicate the joy of these activities. In those pictures arms play a key role - raised to heaven as if in worship, opened wide to invite the world in, gesturing at the wonder the world can still inspire. The widening of the subject matter will include streetwear obsessives, gig goers, DJs, trainer collectors, BMXers and anyone who is no longer considered young but is still at the cutting edge of youth culture.

Wasted On The Young makes no judgement on whether everyone should hold onto a part of their youth so directly, but offers it as a potential path for reconnection with either the world or a sense of self.

THEMES

Youth Culture
Connection
Middle Age
Joy

While this project aims to be in service of an audience that may be concerned about how to grow old while remaining – at least in part – the people they grew up as, it comes from a very personal point of view. In my 30s, I gave up all partying (and associated activities) in order to try and have a baby and a part of me mourned the removal of this key part of my life and identity. I knew how to be young. I didn’t know how to be middle aged.

As with my project about nature, Unmade Beds, I am using the process of photography to engage with the world and to spark new shoots of life within myself. The project is made in spaces that I want to be in, surrounded by people I want to connect with. As Sontag (1977) said, “To photograph is to appropriate the thing photographed,” and in part the project is about me wanting this world for myself again. Quite apart from that, it is extremely important to the project that the picture-making happens from the immersion of the subject rather than as an outsider, a position Sontag was highly critical of in photographers like Arbus. This is something I learned directly through the process of the first part of the project. Unlike documentary photography at the photojournalism end, this is not about parachuting into a space and looking for the exotic or the abject. It is key to show the subjects a respect and an understanding of why they are in this space and what they are trying to achieve both in that moment and in life more generally. As Goldin (1986) says, “I’m not crashing; this is my party.”

With the release of the first part of this project on social media, many older music fans reacted extremely positively to seeing this side of themselves reflected in photos. Discourse around music has a tendency to focus on the young and the new, and while

nobody could ever say that white, middle-class, middle-aged people are under-represented in photography, this is a side that people have reflected that they have not seen often. As John Copeland (1994, reprinted in Art & Photography 2012) said, culture, and specifically photography, sees old as ugly. At the parties Bill Owens photographs in Leisure (2004), the middle-aged attendees are frequently seated rather than pogoing in the moshpit. Martin Parr (1994) shows balding heads hiding under combovers at the races, rather than catching the strobe light. In Larry Sultan's Pictures From Home (1992/2017), his father's early retirement shows a man barely out of middle age, yet we could hardly imagine him leaving Katherine Avenue to go clubbing.

MATERIAL

Stage one of Wasted On The Young was a selection of six A3 inkjet prints on high gloss paper. This was to refer to two key influences in the project: magazines, and prints from developers on the high street. My initial entry point to youth culture came from magazines – first skateboard magazines like RAD, then the music press, and finally and most importantly the style press of The Face, i-D and Dazed & Confused. It was through the latter that I was introduced to Corinne Day and Juergen Teller, and later Elaine Considine and Ewen Spencer, photographers that would form a cornerstone of the look of the images in the project. These photographers balanced the art and commercial space, thanks in part to Cotton's Imperfect Beauty exhibition of 2000. By ripping out the pages from shoots I started to build a world I wanted to inhabit – as Tillmans (2002) said of i-D, these magazines allowed me to create my own identity. The photos blu-tacked to my wall were full bleed, colour images, like the photos of Wasted On The Young.

Like full bleed printing, colour is important in the making of this work, especially in the photos made in music spaces. The rich colours heighten the feelings the vibrancy of the activity. This it brought out further by the use of flash, capturing the motion but leaving the shutter open to flood the picture with washes of colour from the lights. While this gives reference to the snapshot – the memories of a night out recorded on cheap film

cameras and printed on 5x7” paper – it is not intended to be an artless document, one that makes the picture making invisible (Bate, 2015). The work is in conversation with the rich colour work of the photographers working in the 90s style press, who, in turn, draw from British photographers from educational institutions such as Newport, like Anna Fox, Paul Graham and Paul Reas.

A learning point from the first stage of the project is that at A3 the prints feel like they lack the emersion of larger work on a gallery wall. Changing cameras to a 100mp medium format digital camera will offer the chance to make the photographs as large as A0 at 300dpi. Options remain open about whether this a slideshow with music, an installation piece replicating my bedroom as an adolescent, a book, or something else, but initial explorations will start with large scale printing. This takes the work from the documentary format of magazine sized photographs. By presenting the documentary image in a gallery space I hope to tease a more lyrical reading from the viewer, to create a different dialogue that immerses the viewer in the poetic. The work aims to transform, not just record.

AUDIENCE

Speaking on The Messy Truth podcast in 2022, Charlotte Cotton stated her belief that it is “personal experience which unlocks a piece of art” for a potential audience, and that the academic context need to engage with much contemporary art can be a barrier. Wasted On The Young attempts to be a project that lets people in. While not everyone has skateboarded, most people have felt the abandon of dancing, or experienced a passion as a young person that they might want to reconnect with. But even if the viewer doesn’t connect with that reading, there is joy and community running through the pictures to date, something that I will look to include in the images as I continue to shoot. By offering large, sharp pictures with lots of details to read, the audience ought to be able to find a punctum that is poignant to them (Barthes, 1981), leaving the images open to a variety of readings. The audience reaction so far has been enthusiastic through selected images being shown on social media.

RESEARCH

See the collected images and the Stage 1 research dossier following this proposal for a more fleshed out look at the research of this project to date.

TIMELINE

29th August: Submission

15th August: Printing

6th August: Processing

Feb-July: Shooting/Working with feedback/Continued research

Initial shoots will focus on more music events, portrait shoots, photographs of where the middle aged are absent (for example the shed, the bar stool, the armchair).

BUDGET

No equipment purchases are required. Shooting digitally removes film/developing costs. Volume and size of prints are yet to be decided, but options are costed below.

Print prices

A0 Canson High Gloss

£83.20

Framing

My preference is for aluminium mounting, which is costly at A0 which may effect volume or size.

Aluminium and Dibond Mounting

£298.00

FINAL IMAGES



EXHIBITION VIEW





STAGE 1

My initial exploration of an attempted reconnection with music involved my own personal listening and photographing while immersed in music. I aimed to make a diaristic, personal project that put aside narrative and any thoughts of direct representation. The photographs would be titled with the music that was soundtracking the picture making. I titled this 48 Moments Soundtracked.

The avenue quickly came to an end as I wasn't feeling a connection with the music or the picture making. A conversation with Rachel resonated when she asked me "Who's going to be looking at this work when it's done? Who looks at this work and say, I identify with this?"

I reflected on my lack of an answer for this, which led to change in direction.



STAGE 2

The next direction for the project was from a purely documentary standpoint – taking a camera out into the world to try and find older people engaging with youth culture. This proved to be a fruitless task in the main. It lacked the energy and excitement of youth culture, and didn't help with my connection. It also felt at odds with the dialogue that I wanted to maintain with the images that formed my identity through the 1990s.



STAGE 3

My third shoot for the project was useful only in revealing a major change that was needed in my approach. While the outcome was a decent portrait, the experience felt empty. I am not a fan of the Kaiser Chiefs. This might not seem especially important, but it quickly became obvious that it was colouring the photos. I was shooting as an outsider. I didn't go to the gig but stopped people outside afterwards. Whilst people were broadly happy to engage with the process, I couldn't share the excitement of what they had just experienced so seemed like a reporter asking what I missed. The photos outside the venue also didn't read as being part of the music ecosystem.

While they might not enjoy hearing it, The Kaiser Chiefs are now a heritage band. Nostalgia and reliving your youth is a powerful drug, however it is not the strata of people that interest me. There is a considerable difference between nostalgia and engaging with new culture. It is the latter that I want to reconnect with, so I made a point of heading to smaller venues in future to see new bands and DJs.



STAGE 4

The Umlauts are a band that look like the result of a particularly interesting international squat party jam session – they are young and quirky and brought a diverse crowd to the Green Door Store. I was looking for details and spotted the difference between the sensible shoes on some of the audience members and the ankle socks and heels of a band member.

The low light in the venue encouraged the use of flash. This felt like the project was heading in the right direction.



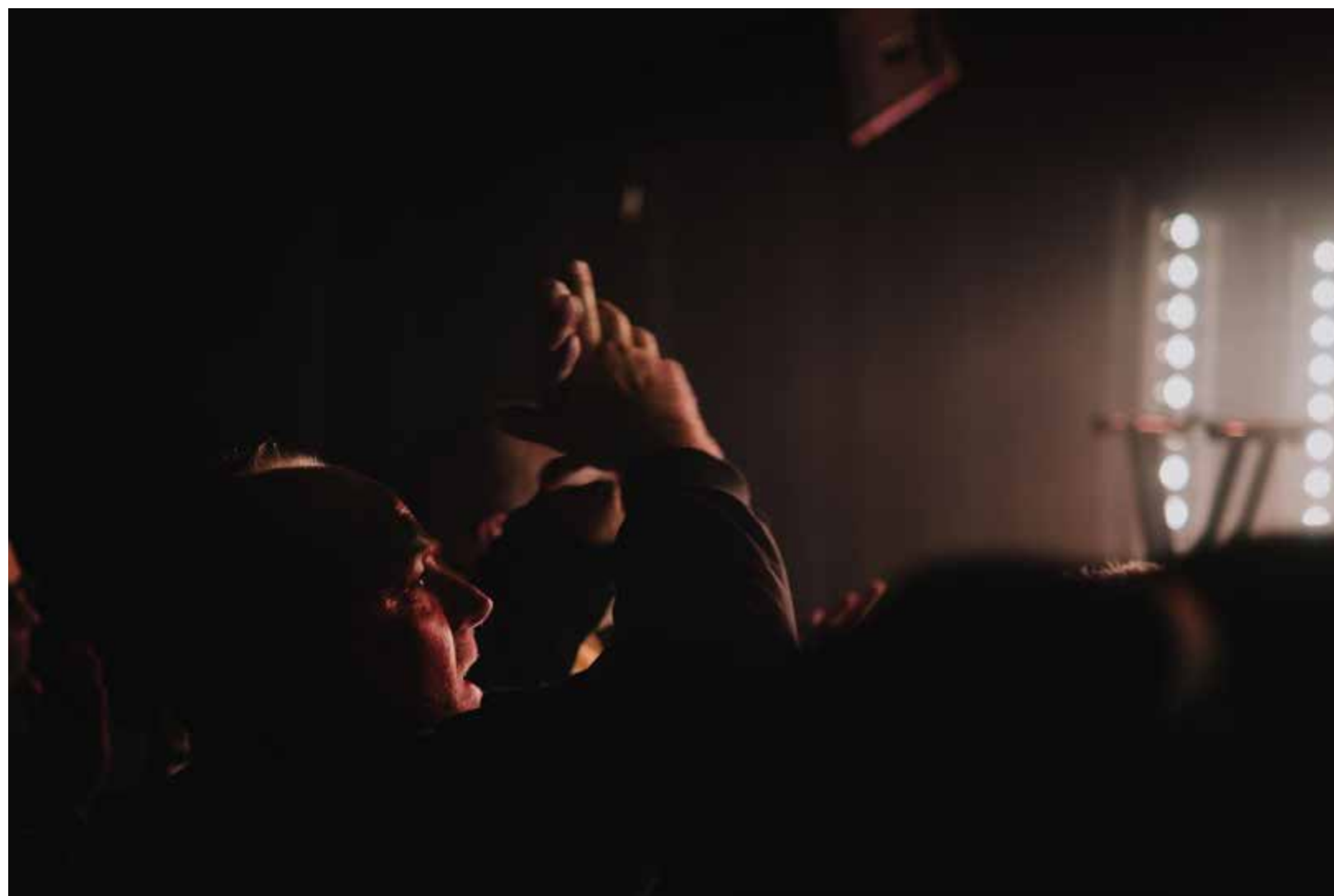
STAGE 5

2manyDJs are a DJ duo that have a long history in dance music but still play new records – currently techno of varying levels of abrasiveness. This combination leads to a very mixed crowd that features those from their early 20s to mid 50s. These photos were taken from the dancefloor, stopping dancing to click the shutter. Being part of the crowd felt key, shooting not from outside. Because of this people seemed relaxed about having their photo taken, meaning that I was able to capture reactions to the music rather than the picture making. Using a 50mm lens to compress the scene, I wanted to fill the frame to replicate that feeling of being crushed in the action.



STAGE 6

After hearing about my project, a skateboarder invited me to shoot at the skatepark his group of older skaters hire out weekly. The photos were a mix of actions shots (which turned out to be the least interesting), portraits and documentary shots. Much of this work was shot on medium format digital, something that really helped in exploring the details in the work. For stage two of the project I aim to use medium format digital to be able to show the work larger than typical documentary size. One shot that felt like a future direction for the project was a skateboard with artificial texture against a wooden barrier. While this didn't make the edit or this first iteration due to there not being enough images of this type, it is something I want to explore for stage two. The formal portraits are something I also want to explore in stage two. I'd like to try and combine photos of the moment, formal portraits, and naturally occurring still lives in a manner similar to Zed Nelson's *Gun Nation*, or the work of Alec Soth and Gregory Halpern.



STAGE 7

Like The Umlauts gig, Nation Of Language brought out music fans that are interested in new music across a wide age spectrum. The light in these pictures, reflected off the stage, has a different quality to the other photos and, while I grapple with how to manage that, these photos didn't make it into the final edit. They do however share a sense of joy with the pictures from the 2manyDJs show.



STAGE 8

Widening the project from organised youth culture events, I started to bring my camera out with me to the places I experienced music in a more informal setting. These photos show middle aged people at parties, drinking and dancing in pubs and social clubs. The relaxed nature of these events mean that a sense of joy comes across easily in the photographs. Most of these people are known to me, and are relaxed in front of my camera.